



History of the Walkman

Find a visual history of the iconic Sony Walkman, in this gallery of the device in use over the years. <https://digit.in/aug20-39>



Origins of the Walkman

The Walkman was originally targeted at journalists, and was going to be called the Pressman. <https://digit.in/aug20-40>

Portable music players

The origins and evolution of music on-the-go

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usic has crept its way into almost every person's life, becoming an essential part of one's routine. Today,

we have instantaneous access to music via our smartphones through music streaming apps such as Spotify, Google Play Music, and others. Users can also store a plethora of tracks onto their device since most smartphones today come equipped with significant onboard storage. Portable music isn't an issue now, but it certainly was in the past. Before the invention of pocket-sized music players, people had to lug around heavy, lunchbox-sized 'portable' radio players that came fitted with vacuum tubes and massive batteries. However, with the invention of truly 'portable' music players, music started becoming more popular since it freed people from the shackles of having to stay at home to listen to music, to a point where music is an indispensable medium of entertainment in most people's lives today. Let's go through the journey of portable music players and the milestones along the way.

PORTABLE TRANSISTOR RADIO

The Regency TR-1 was the world's first commercially-produced portable transistor radio. The product hit the market in October 1954 and weighed merely 311 grams. The device featured a 22.5-volt battery and could power through about 24 hours of usage. The 'pocket radio' was invented by Texas Instruments and I.D.E.A. and was expected to have 40 million in sales in the first year.



Credit: Cesare Andrea Ferrari / Shutterstock.com

However, the product got nowhere near those estimates primarily due to the exorbitant \$49.95 price point. Nevertheless, the Regency TR-1 did kick off the journey of making music-listening a more personal affair. In 1955, the second transistor radio, the Raytheon 8-TP-1 was introduced which was significantly larger than the Regency TR-1, since it featured a four-inch speaker and four additional transistors. Soon after, Sony (then called Tokyo Tsushin Kogyo) launched the TR-55 portable transistor radio featuring five transistors in a very compact form factor.

COMPACT CASSETTE TAPE RECORDER

In 1965, Philips released the first-ever compact cassette tape that could record 45 minutes of sound on a single 1/4-inch tape. Complementing this innovation, the company released a Compact Cassette Tape Recorder, dubbed the Norelco Carry-Corder 150 recorder and player. The Norelco Carry Corder 150 was battery-powered and weighed in at about 1.3kg (when it was loaded with a cassette). Users could record music onto a compact cassette with this device and then play the music on the go. By 1966, Philips sold over 250,000 record-

ers in the US alone and by 1968, several manufacturers joined the ride and together sold over 2.4 million compact cassette tape recorders. Cassette and 8-track tapes dominated the portable music world for the next two decades.

BOOMBOX

Commercially introduced by various companies in the late 1970s, the Boombox added stereo capabilities to already-existing radio-cassette record-



Sony M9998LU Boombox (1979-1980)

ers. The boombox was first developed in the Netherlands in 1969 and it was the first device through which radio could be recorded on cassette tapes without using cables or a microphone. Early boombox models were usually black, bulky and pretty loud. They incorporated an AM and FM tuner, and subsequent models also added input and output jacks, allowing for